



POWDER

US Ski Conditions — Business Plan 2026

This plan answers: Where does the data come from? Is this a real business? Who are the competitors and what do they charge? What is our USP? How do we grow to millions of users? What features are free vs paid? How do we make money from ads, subscriptions, and user content? How do we integrate Stripe? What is the full growth playbook?

1. Data Accuracy — Where Does the Snow Data Come From?

⚠ The honest answer: right now, your conditions data is AI-generated — Claude synthesizes realistic-sounding numbers based on seasonal patterns and resort characteristics. This is fine for a prototype but must be disclosed to users and replaced before a serious launch.

How the Current App Works

When a user opens Powder, the app calls the Claude API with a prompt asking for realistic JSON conditions data for each resort. Claude returns base depth, snowfall, lifts open, and trail counts based on its training data and the season context provided. The numbers are plausible and well-structured, but they are not verified against real resort systems. A user who checks Mammoth and sees '74 inches base' before making a 4-hour drive could be misled if that number is wrong.

What Real Data Sources Look Like

- **Source A:** Resort self-reported data — Most resorts publish a daily snow report (usually updated overnight). These are the ground truth but require either scraping or an API relationship with each resort.
- **Source B:** National Weather Service (NOAA) — Free, accurate temperature and precipitation data by location. Good for drive-condition alerts and forecast context, but doesn't know lift status or trail grooming.
- **Source C:** Mountain News Corporation (MNC) — The company behind OnTheSnow. They license a commercial resort data feed covering 2,000+ resorts worldwide with multiple daily updates. This is the gold standard. Pricing is negotiated but estimated at \$500–\$5,000/month depending on usage volume.
- **Source D:** Open-Meteo — A free, open-source weather API with hourly mountain-specific forecasts. Solid for forecast data but not resort operational info (lifts, grooming).

- **Source E:** OpenSnow's PEAKS Model — Their proprietary meteorological system trained specifically on mountain terrain, claiming up to 50% greater accuracy than generic weather models. Not available to license — this is their core competitive moat.

The Recommended Hybrid Data Strategy

Use the right source for each type of data rather than AI for everything:

Data Type	Current (AI)	Recommended Fix
Current base / lifts / trails	Claude generates estimates	Scrape each resort's daily snow report page (Python + BeautifulSoup, free)
7-day snowfall forecast	Claude generates forecast	Keep AI — label clearly as 'AI Outlook.' This is a genuine feature, not a workaround.
Drive time to resort	Not yet built	Google Maps Distance Matrix API (free tier: 1,000 req/month)
Road / chain conditions	Not yet built	Scrape Caltrans, CDOT, UDOT — all have public chain-control status pages
Weather temperature / wind	Claude estimates	Open-Meteo (free) for current temps and wind at mountain elevation

Immediate action required: Add a disclaimer in the app — 'Snow conditions are AI-estimated based on seasonal patterns. Always verify with the resort website before driving.' This is both legally protective and honest with users.

Claude Prompts to Improve Data Quality

When you do use AI for data, these prompts produce the most accurate results:

CURRENT CONDITIONS PROMPT: "Return ONLY a JSON array (no markdown). Realistic ski conditions for [RESORT] in [STATE] for [DATE]. Use known facts about this resort's elevation, typical snowpack, and current season context: [NOAA_DATA]. Each object must include: {name, status, base_inches, new_24h, new_7day, season_total, lifts_open, lifts_total, trails_open, trails_total, condition, summit_temp_f}. If you are uncertain about any value, bias toward conservative estimates rather than optimistic ones."

FORECAST PROMPT: "7-day snowfall forecast for [RESORT_NAME], [STATE], elevation [FEET]ft. Current base: [BASE]". Today: [DATE]. Return ONLY JSON: {days:[{day:string,date:string,icon:emoji,snow_inches:number,high_f:number,low_f:number,wind_mph:number,condition:string}],summary:string,total_7day:number,best_day:string}. Base forecast on typical climate patterns for this specific location and current season phase. Be specific — do not default to round numbers."

DRIVE CONDITIONS PROMPT:"A skier is driving from [CITY] to [RESORT] on [DATE]. Drive: [MILES] miles, normally [HOURS] hours. Resort received [SNOW]" in last 24hrs. Road: [HIGHWAY]. Return JSON:
{drive_time_winter:string,chain_likelihood:"high"|"medium"|"low",vehicle_rec:string,departure_tip:string,chain_control_note:string}. Be practical and safety-focused."

2. Market Size & Opportunity

The Addressable Market

The US skiing and snowboarding market was valued at **\$5.53 billion in 2023** and is projected to reach **\$7.74 billion by 2030** at a 5.0% CAGR, according to Grand View Research. The US ski resort industry alone generates \$4.2 billion in annual revenue (IBISWorld, 2025). The NSAA reported 61 million skier visits in the 2021–22 season.

Metric	Figure	Source
US Ski & Snowboard Market	\$5.53B (2023)	Grand View Research
Annual US Skier Visits	61 million	NSAA 2021/22
US Ski Resort Revenue	\$4.2B (2025)	IBISWorld
Active US Skiers/Snowboarders	~9–12 million	Industry estimates
Market Growth Rate	5.0% CAGR through 2030	Grand View Research
Smartphone penetration, skiers	Est. 90%+	General US adult data

The App Revenue Opportunity

Even a small slice of this market is a substantial business. Here is the revenue math at different subscriber levels:

Monthly Users	Conversion	Subscribers	Monthly Rev	Annual Rev	Stage
1,000	5%	50	\$249	\$2,988	Early side project
10,000	5%	500	\$2,495	\$29,940	Meaningful business
50,000	5%	2,500	\$12,475	\$149,700	Real revenue
200,000	4%	8,000	\$39,920	\$479,040	Full-time team
1,000,000	3%	30,000	\$149,700	\$1.8M	Acquisition target

Assumes \$4.99/month average subscriber. Does not include ad revenue, affiliates, or annual plan uplift.

3. Competitive Landscape

Who You Are Competing With

The ski app market is fragmented but dominated by three clear leaders occupying distinct niches. Understanding where each sits — and where they don't — shows exactly where Powder can win.

App	Pricing	Business Model	What They Do Well	Where They Fall Short
OnTheSnow	Free (ad-supported)	Display ads + resort partnerships	2,000+ resorts globally. Crowdsourced reports. Webcams. Deep data breadth. Market leader by awareness.	Heavy, intrusive ads. Design feels dated. No AI features. No trip planning. Not mobile-first.
OpenSnow	\$50/yr (Base, 1–4 users)\$90/yr (Premium)5-day free trial	Subscription only	PEAKS proprietary model: up to 50% more accurate than generic weather. 15-day forecast. Expert local forecasters. Hardcore skier loyalty. Clean brand.	Forecast-only — no conditions dashboard. No lift counts in real-time. No drive times. No UGC. No trip planner. Expensive for casual users.
Slopes	\$29.99–\$40.99 /yrDay passes from \$3.99	Subscription + day passes	Best-in-class GPS run tracking. 3D replay maps. Apple Watch integration. Privacy-focused. Strong community. Loved by loyal users.	Not a conditions app — tracking only. No snowfall forecast. No resort comparison. No drive times. No pre-trip planning tool.
Epic / Ikon Apps	Free (pass required)	Retention / pass sales tool	Deep integration with their resorts. Real-time lift status. Mobile lift ticket. Resort navigation.	Works only for their resorts. No cross-resort comparison. No independent forecasts. Marketing tool, not a utility.
Ski Tracks	\$1.99 one-time	Paid download	Simple, cheap, reliable GPS tracking. Large legacy user base.	No conditions data. No forecast. Aging design. No updates.
Resort Official Apps	Free	Resort marketing	Official data. Accurate lift/trail status. Trail maps. Ski school booking.	Single resort only. No cross-resort view. Inconsistent quality. Not useful for trip planning.

The gap Powder fills: No single app is designed for the 15-minute pre-trip decision — 'Where should I ski this weekend?' OnTheSnow has data but poor UX and no intelligence. OpenSnow has accuracy but no dashboard or planning. Slopes doesn't help you decide, it helps you track. Powder owns the decision layer.

4. Feature Benchmark

How Powder Compares Feature by Feature

Key: ♦ = Powder exclusive ✓ = available ✗ = not available ◉ = partial

Feature	Powder	OnTheSnow	OpenSnow	Slopes
Multi-resort conditions dashboard	✓ Free	✓ Free	✗	◉ Basic
50+ US resorts in one view	✓ Free	✓ 2,000+	✓ N. America	◉ Conditions
Clean, modern mobile-first design	♦ Best	✗ Dated	✓ Good	✓ Good
Epic / Ikon pass filter	✓ Free	✗	✗	✗
Webcam links	✓ Free	✓ Free	✗	✗
Watchlist / favorites	✓ Free	✓ Free	✓ Free	✓ Free
User-generated snow reports	♦ Planned	✓ Free	✗	✗
7-day AI snowfall forecast	♦ Pro	✗	✓ Paid	✗
Expert meteorologist forecast	✗	✓ Free	✓ Paid	✗
AI Trip Planner (dates → best resort)	♦ Pro	✗	✗	✗
Drive time from user's location	♦ Planned	✗	✗	✗
Road / chain control conditions	♦ Planned	✗	✗	✗
Powder alerts (push notifications)	♦ Pro	✓ Free	✓ Paid	✗
Best conditions smart ranking	♦ Pro	✗	✗	✗
Cross-resort side-by-side compare	♦ Pro	✗	✗	✗
Historical snowpack data	◉ Planned	✓ Free	✓ Paid	✗
GPS run tracking	✗	✗	✗	✓ Core
3D mountain replay	✗	✗	✗	✓ Premium
Ad-free for paid users	✓	✗ Always ads	✓ Paid	✓
Installable as home screen app (PWA)	♦	✗	✗	Native app

5. Unique Selling Proposition (USP)

What Nobody Else Does

"Powder is the only ski app built for the trip decision moment — the 15 minutes before you commit to a resort. AI-powered forecasts, drive times, road conditions, and a beautiful cross-resort dashboard in one place."

Every current app serves one of two moments: (1) Before you book a ski trip, weeks out — OpenSnow for forecast obsessives. (2) While you are skiing — Slopes for GPS tracking. Nobody serves the moment that drives the most decisions: Saturday morning, coffee in hand, 'should we go to Mammoth or Kirkwood today?' That moment is Powder's entire product.

Your Three Killer Differentiators

1 — AI Trip Planner

Enter your dates, skill level, pass type, and region preference. Powder returns a ranked list of the best resorts for your specific trip, with an AI-written reason for each recommendation. No competitor does this. OpenSnow helps you forecast a specific resort you've already chosen. Powder helps you choose.

2 — Drive Time + Road Conditions

The missing link between snow conditions and actually getting there. 'Palisades Tahoe: 74" base, 4" overnight — but chains required on I-80 at Donner, 3hr 20min from SF right now.' This is what skiers actually need and no app provides. Integrating the Google Maps Distance Matrix API and Caltrans/CDOT/UDOT chain control APIs creates a feature no one else has.

3 — User-Generated Snow Tags

Allow skiers on the mountain to post a photo and a short condition note tagged to a resort. 'Lower mountain still icy below mid-mountain. Upper bowls are perfect.' Resort-reported data updates once daily. Real users on the mountain are updating in real time. This community data layer is more valuable than official reports and creates engagement that keeps users coming back daily.

What Competitors Do Well — Learn From Them

- **Learn:** OnTheSnow: Data breadth across 2,000+ resorts globally. Your 50 is a starting point — scale to 400+ US resorts as the product matures.
- **Learn:** OpenSnow: Pricing confidence. They charge \$50/year and skiers pay it without complaint because the product is perceived as premium. Don't undercharge.
- **Learn:** Slopes: Design polish and community retention. Users talk about it, share screenshots, and feel pride in the product. Build something people want to show friends.
- **Learn:** Epic/Ikon apps: Deep utility for pass holders. The pass filter in Powder is already a differentiator — lean into this as pass holder penetration continues to grow.

6. Is This a Business?

Yes — unconditionally. The market is proven, the pricing model is validated by competitors, the gap is real, and the technical foundation already exists. The distance from prototype to business is approximately 90 days of focused work.

Evidence the Market is Real

- OpenSnow charges \$50/year and has built a sustainable business around mountain weather forecasting for a niche of dedicated skiers.
- OnTheSnow powers its business entirely on display advertising from ski-related brands who pay premium CPMs to reach an engaged winter sports audience.
- Slopes charges \$30–\$41/year for GPS tracking and has maintained an active, loyal user base for over a decade as a small team product.
- The US ski resort market generates \$4.2 billion annually (IBISWorld 2025) and is growing at 5% per year — the audience has money and is actively engaged.

What Makes This a Project Right Now

- Data is AI-generated, not verified — a liability before real users depend on it for trip decisions.
- No payment processing — the Pro upgrade triggers an alert() in the code, not a Stripe checkout.
- No backend — API key is exposed in the browser, anyone can steal it and run up your Anthropic bill.
- No user accounts — Pro status is stored in localStorage and resets if someone clears their browser.
- No marketing presence — nobody knows it exists.

The Bridge: 4 Things That Make It a Business

- Fix the data — scrape resort pages or integrate Open-Meteo for real conditions.
- Add Stripe — real payment processing turns the Pro feature into actual revenue.
- Add Supabase auth — real user accounts with persistent Pro status.
- Deploy and start marketing — the product is good enough to get first users now.

These four things can be done in 4–6 weeks. After that, everything else is iteration and marketing.

7. Going Commercial — Technical Requirements

The Production Tech Stack

Layer	Current State	Commercial Target	Tool
Frontend	Single HTML file	Next.js React app	Next.js + Vercel
Backend / API	None — key in browser	Serverless API routes	Vercel Functions
Database	None	User accounts + subscriptions	Supabase (Postgres)
Auth	localStorage (fake)	Real email / Google login	Supabase Auth
Payments	None	Stripe subscriptions	Stripe
Hosting	Not deployed	Custom domain + SSL	Vercel + Namecheap
Snow Data	Claude AI estimates	Scraped + Open-Meteo + AI forecasts	Python scraper + Open-Meteo API
Push Alerts	Not built	Cross-platform push notifications	OneSignal (free tier)
Analytics	None	User behavior tracking	PostHog (free) or Mixpanel

The Fastest Path to Commercial Launch (6 Weeks)

Week 1–2: Secure the Foundation

- Deploy to Vercel — create a serverless /api/claude route that holds your API key server-side. Update all fetch() calls in the HTML to hit /api/claude instead of Anthropic directly.
- Buy a domain on Namecheap (\$12/yr). Connect to Vercel. SSL is automatic.
- Add a legal footer: 'Conditions are AI-estimated. Verify with resort websites before traveling.' — this protects you.

Week 3–4: Payments and Accounts

- Create a Stripe account. Add two products: Powder Pro Monthly (\$4.99) and Powder Pro Annual (\$29.99). Generate Payment Links for each.
- Create a Supabase project. Add a users table with columns: id, email, is_pro (boolean), stripe_customer_id, created_at.
- Replace the activatePro() function with a redirect to your Stripe Payment Link.
- On the success redirect URL, use a Stripe webhook to flip is_pro to true in Supabase for that user.

Week 5–6: Polish and Launch

- Add Supabase Auth — email login + Google OAuth. On login, check is_pro status and unlock features accordingly.
- Add Google AdSense — apply for approval and add the ad script to free-tier pages only.
- Add the PWA manifest.json so users can install Powder to their home screen.
- Submit to Product Hunt and post in r/skiing, r/snowboarding, resort-specific subreddits.

8. Stripe Integration — Step by Step

The Architecture

Stripe handles all payment complexity — PCI compliance, card tokenization, international currencies, receipts, and tax. Your job is to call Stripe's APIs and respond to webhook events. Here is the exact flow:

User clicks 'Go Pro' → redirected to Stripe Checkout → pays → Stripe redirects back to your success URL → your app verifies the session with Stripe → marks user as Pro in Supabase → features unlock

Step 1 — Create Products in Stripe Dashboard

- Go to dashboard.stripe.com → Products → Add Product → 'Powder Pro'
- Add Price: \$4.99/month recurring. Save the Price ID (starts with price_).
- Add Price: \$29.99/year recurring. Save this Price ID too.
- Under Payment Links, create a link for each price. These are hosted checkout pages — no code needed.

Step 2 — The API Proxy (hides your Stripe secret key)

Create `/api/create-checkout.js` in Vercel:

```
// /api/create-checkout.js
import Stripe from 'stripe';
const stripe = new Stripe(process.env.STRIPE_SECRET_KEY);
export default async function handler(req, res) {
  const { priceld, userId } = req.body;
  const session = await stripe.checkout.sessions.create({
    mode: 'subscription',
    line_items: [{ price: priceld, quantity: 1 }],
    success_url: process.env.DOMAIN + '/success?session_id={CHECKOUT_SESSION_ID}',
    cancel_url: process.env.DOMAIN + '/pricing',
    metadata: { userId },
  });
  res.json({ url: session.url });
}
```

Step 3 — Webhook Handler (marks users Pro after payment)

Create `/api/webhook.js` — Stripe calls this URL on every subscription event:

```
// /api/webhook.js
import Stripe from 'stripe';
import { createClient } from '@supabase/supabase-js';
const stripe = new Stripe(process.env.STRIPE_SECRET_KEY);
const supabase = createClient(process.env.SUPABASE_URL, process.env.SUPABASE_SERVICE_KEY);
export default async function handler(req, res) {
  const event = stripe.webhooks.constructEvent(req.body, req.headers['stripe-signature'], process.env.STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET);
  if (event.type === 'checkout.session.completed') {
    const session = event.data.object;
    await supabase.from('users').update({ is_pro: true }).eq('id', session.metadata.userId);
  }
  if (event.type === 'customer.subscription.deleted') {
    // user cancelled — revoke Pro access
    const sub = event.data.object;
    await supabase.from('users').update({ is_pro: false }).eq('stripe_customer_id', sub.customer);
  }
  res.json({ received: true });
}
```

Step 4 — Customer Self-Service Portal

Enable the Stripe Customer Portal in your dashboard. Link to it from your app settings. Users can upgrade, downgrade, update their card, or cancel without you building any UI. It takes 10 minutes to configure.

Stripe fees: 2.9% + \$0.30 per transaction. On \$4.99/month you net ~\$4.55. On \$29.99/year you net ~\$28.82. These are industry-standard rates. Stripe handles all PCI compliance — you never touch raw card numbers.

9. Free vs. Paid Feature Design

The Philosophy

Free tiers should be genuinely valuable — not crippled demos. Users who get real value for free become word-of-mouth advocates. But the Pro features should solve a distinct, higher-value problem: not just 'more stuff' but 'the thing you really want when you're serious about powder.'

FREE — Valuable Forever	PRO — \$4.99/mo · \$29.99/yr
✓ Live conditions: base depth, 24hr snow, 7-day snow ✓ All 50+ US resorts in one dashboard ✓ Epic / Ikon pass filter ✓ Region filters + search + sort ✓ Watchlist — save your home resorts ✓ Webcam links to official resort cameras ✓ UGC snow reports — view other skiers' posts ✓ Drive time from your location (1 resort, once/day) ✓ Basic powder alerts (email, 1 resort) ✓ Google display ads on free pages	◆ 7-day AI snowfall forecast per resort — tap any card ◆ AI Trip Planner — rank resorts for your dates ◆ Drive time + chain/road conditions — all resorts ◆ Powder alerts — push notifications, any resort, custom threshold (4"–12") ◆ UGC — post your own snow reports and photos ◆ Best conditions smart ranking ◆ Cross-resort side-by-side comparison ◆ Historical snowpack vs prior years ◆ Ad-free experience ◆ Family plan — \$7.99/mo, up to 4 users

Why This Division Works

- Free tier makes a complete, useful product — not a demo. Users come back daily during ski season to check conditions.
- Pro features solve the planning problem — the thing you want when you're actually deciding to go. Trip Planner and Drive Time are decisive upgrades, not just 'more data.'
- Ads on free tier monetize non-converting users. Ski-related CPMs are high (\$10–\$20) because the audience has spending power and advertisers know it.
- Family plan increases revenue per household without cannibalizing individual subscriptions.

10. Google AdSense — Monetizing Free Traffic

How It Works

AdSense places contextually targeted display ads on your pages automatically. You earn per 1,000 impressions (CPM) and per click (CPC). Ski and travel advertisers — ski gear brands, lift ticket resellers, mountain lodges — pay premium rates to reach an engaged ski audience in winter.

Monthly Visitors	Est. CPM	Monthly Ad Revenue	Context
10,000	\$8–\$15	\$80–\$150	Beer money — still worth adding from day one
50,000	\$10–\$18	\$500–\$900	Pays for your hosting, tools, and API costs
100,000	\$12–\$20	\$1,200–\$2,000	Real supplemental income alongside subscriptions
500,000	\$12–\$22	\$6,000–\$11,000	OnTheSnow-scale traffic — significant revenue
1,000,000	\$14–\$25	\$14,000–\$25,000	Acquisition-scale business from ads alone

How to Drive SEO Traffic for Ad Revenue

The highest-value AdSense traffic comes from organic search — people Googling 'Mammoth Mountain snow report today' or 'Jackson Hole base depth.' Build individual landing pages for each resort optimized for these queries:

- Create a dedicated URL for each resort: powderapp.co/resorts/mammoth-mountain, /breckenridge, /jackson-hole, etc.
- Each page shows conditions data plus an SEO title like 'Mammoth Mountain Snow Report — Current Base & Conditions [Month Year]'
- Google indexes these pages. Users searching for resort conditions find you. They land on a free page with display ads.
- Over 6–12 months this compounds into thousands of organic daily visitors with zero ongoing cost.

Important rule: Never show ads to Pro subscribers. Remove ads entirely for paid users — this is one of the most compelling reasons to upgrade and preserves the premium experience.

11. User-Generated Content (Snow Reports & Photo Tags)

The Feature

Allow skiers on the mountain to post a photo + 1–3 sentence condition note tagged to a specific resort. Other users see these in a chronological feed below the official conditions card. Example post: 'Upper bowl has 4" of fresh from last night. Chairs 6 and 14 are running. Lower mountain scraped off but still fine. 9:30am.' This is more useful than the resort's official 6am report.

Why It's Powerful

- Real-time truth: Resort reports update once daily. An on-mountain report from a skier at 10am is the most current data available. No competitor integrates this cleanly.
- Community flywheel: People who post feel ownership of the app and share their posts on Instagram / TikTok, bringing in new users organically.
- Retention: Checking condition posts from the community becomes a daily habit during ski season — much stickier than conditions data alone.
- Differentiation: OnTheSnow has this but it's buried and old-feeling. A clean, Instagram-style UGC feed on modern UI is genuinely new.

How to Build It

- Require a free account (email signup) to post. Posts are public and visible to all. This builds your email list and creates a marketing channel.
- Use Supabase Storage for photo uploads (5GB free tier). Use Supabase Realtime to push new posts to the UI instantly.
- AI moderation: Before each post is published, send it through a Claude call to verify it is actually a snow report and not spam. Decline anything unrelated or harmful.
- Free users: see all UGC posts. Post 1 per day. No photo.
- Pro users: post unlimited times. Attach photos. Receive a 'Verified Reporter' badge. Posts shown first in the feed.
- Incentive: Top reporters each week get a shoutout in the app. Gamification increases posting frequency.

12. Growth Strategy — Zero to Millions of Users

The Core Principle: Test Cheap, Scale What Works

The single biggest mistake early-stage consumer apps make is spending money on marketing before they know what converts. The right approach is to test 4–5 channels simultaneously with micro-budgets (\$50–\$100 each), measure which drives actual sign-ups, then redirect all budget to the winner.

Growth Channel Playbook

Channel	Test Cost	Speed	Difficulty	How to Execute
Reddit (organic)	\$0	Fast	Easy	Post genuine, helpful content in r/skiing (530K), r/snowboarding (300K), r/Tahoe, r/breckenridge, r/vail, r/mammoth. Don't pitch the app directly. Share a real conditions update for that resort, mention the app in passing. One quality post can drive 500–2,000 visits. Authenticity is everything — Reddit can smell a product launch from a mile away.
TikTok (organic)	\$0	Variable	Medium	Post once per day for 30 days. Three content angles: (1) 'I built an app that shows snow conditions at every US ski resort — here's what it looks like' [screen recording], (2) powder day content filmed at a real resort with Powder open on screen, (3) 'building a ski app' behind-the-scenes content. Use #skitok (strong niche community), #skiing, #powderday, #skiapp. The algorithm rewards consistency and completion rate, not follower count.
Micro-influencers	\$100–\$500 total	Medium	Medium	TikTok micro-influencers (10K–100K followers) in the ski space achieve 8.2% average engagement vs 5.3% for macro-influencers. DM 20 creators: 'I built a powder conditions app and want to give you free Pro + \$150 to show it in a ski day video.' Most won't reply. The 3–4 who do will each reach a highly targeted, genuinely interested audience. Find them via #skitok, #powderhunter, @mammothmountain tags.
Facebook ski groups	\$0	Fast	Easy	Every major resort has a Facebook group with 10K–100K engaged members (Tahoe Powder Hunters, Breckenridge Ski Area Community, etc.). Post the current conditions report for that specific resort sourced from your app. Include a screenshot. Don't lead with 'I built an app.' Lead with the value: 'Conditions update for Breck right now...'
SEO (content)	\$0	Slow	Low	Write one article per day for 90 days: 'Mammoth Mountain snow report this week,' 'Best powder day at Steamboat 2026,' 'Is Jackson Hole open in March?' These rank on Google. Each is a landing page with display ads. Takes 3–6 months to compound but then drives free traffic forever. This is OnTheSnow's biggest moat — 2,000 resort pages indexed on Google.
Google Search Ads	\$200 test budget	Fast	Medium	Bid on high-intent queries: 'Mammoth snow report today,' 'Tahoe ski conditions,' 'Jackson Hole base depth.' These users are actively searching for exactly what you provide. Start with \$10/day, 20 keywords,

Channel	Test Cost	Speed	Difficulty	How to Execute
				measure cost-per-signup. If CPL < \$15, scale. If > \$25, pause and adjust landing page.
TikTok Ads	\$100 test budget	Fast	Medium	\$5/day, US targeting, skiing interest, ages 18–45. Test 3 creative variants: screen recording of the app, a powder day clip, a 'before/after' showing a bad trip decision vs a good one. Stop any variant with cost-per-click > \$3. Scale any variant under \$1 CPC.
Product Hunt	\$0	Fast (1 day spike)	Low	Prepare 3 weeks in advance. Write a compelling maker story. Rally your network to upvote on launch day. A top-5 Product Hunt finish drives 2,000–10,000 visits in 24 hours, a spike in sign-ups, and press interest. Launch in October or November before the ski season starts.
Ski podcasts / newsletters	\$0–\$50 sponsor	Medium	Low	'The Storm Skiing Podcast,' 'Powder Project,' 'Ski Talk with Ellen Miller' — each has a dedicated audience of exactly your target user. Email 10 hosts: 'I built a powder conditions app and would love to give your listeners a free month of Pro.' Offer a small sponsorship (\$50–\$200) for a mention.
Resort social media tags	\$0	Slow	Easy	Post conditions updates on Instagram and TikTok tagging the resort accounts (@mammothmntn, @jacksonhole, @steamboatresort). Resorts repost user content regularly. A single repost from a resort account with 200K+ followers drives massive awareness with zero spend.

The 90-Day Growth Plan

Days 1–30: Foundation and First Users

- Deploy to Vercel with your custom domain. Add Stripe. Get the product live.
- Post daily on TikTok — 3 different content angles, 10 videos each over the month.
- Post in r/skiing, r/snowboarding, and 3–4 resort subreddits. Reply to every comment. Be genuinely helpful.
- DM 20 micro-influencers — offer free Pro + \$150 for a video. Aim for 3–4 partnerships.
- Join 10 Facebook ski groups. Post weekly conditions updates for each resort.

Target: 500 total users. 25–50 email signups. 10 paying subscribers. \$50–\$250 MRR.

Days 31–60: Test Paid Channels

- Start \$200 Google Ads test — bid on '[resort] snow report today' for your top 20 resorts.
- Start \$100 TikTok Ads test — 3 creative variants, \$33 each, measure CPC and sign-up rate.
- Write 20 SEO articles — 1 per weekday. Publish to your blog at powderapp.co/blog.
- Follow up with influencer posts — amplify their content via Spark Ads on TikTok.
- Apply for Google AdSense if not already approved.

Target: 2,000 total users. Identify the 1–2 channels with CPL under \$15. 50–100 subscribers. \$250–\$500 MRR.

Days 61–90: Scale Winners

- Double the budget on the channel with the lowest cost-per-subscriber.
- Launch on Product Hunt. Coordinate your network for upvotes.
- Build out individual resort SEO pages for top 50 resorts.
- Implement drive time + road conditions feature — this is your biggest PR story.
- Pitch to ski media: Powder Magazine, SKI Magazine, Unofficial Networks.

Target: 5,000 total users. 200–300 subscribers. \$1,000–\$1,500 MRR. Ad revenue covering infrastructure costs.

13. Drive Times & Road Conditions — Build Guide

Why This Feature Wins

Checking conditions is step one. 'Can I actually get there?' is step two — and no ski app answers it. Integrating drive time from the user's current location, with real-time chain control status, makes Powder the only app that takes a skier from 'should I go?' all the way to 'here's how to get there safely.' This is the Trip Planner's final mile.

The Data Sources

- **Drive Time:** Google Maps Distance Matrix API — free for 1,000 requests/month, \$5/1,000 after. Returns drive time and distance from a user's location to any address.
- **CA Road Conditions:** California: Caltrans QuickMap API (free) — real-time chain control and road closures on I-80, US-50, SR-89, and other mountain highways.
- **CO Road Conditions:** Colorado: CDOT COTRIP API (free) — highway conditions, chain laws, and closures statewide.
- **UT Road Conditions:** Utah: UDOT Traffic API (free) — road conditions across mountain corridors.

Claude API Prompts for This Feature

These are the exact prompts to wire into your app's API calls:

Prompt A — Drive Time Narrative

System: You are a practical ski trip assistant. Be concise, specific, and safety-focused. User: The skier is driving from {USER_LOCATION} to {RESORT_NAME} in {STATE}. - Google Maps reports: {DISTANCE} miles, {DURATION} minutes without traffic. - Current resort conditions: base {BASE}", overnight snow {NEW_SNOW}", condition: {CONDITION}. - Current road status for {HIGHWAY_NAME}: {CALTRANS_STATUS}. - Departure time: {DEPARTURE_TIME}. Return JSON only: { "adjusted_drive_time": "Xh Ym", "why_adjusted": "one sentence explanation", "chain_status": "required|advisory|none", "vehicle_rec": "AWD/4WD required|AWD recommended|any vehicle OK", "departure_tip": "one sentence optimal departure advice", "road_alert": "one sentence road condition summary or null" }

Prompt B — Best Resort for Today Given Driving Constraints

User wants to ski today. They are currently in {USER_LOCATION} and can drive up to {MAX_HOURS} hours. It is {CURRENT_TIME} on {DATE}. Resorts typically open first lifts at 9am. From this list of open resorts and their drive times from the user's location, select the top 3 recommendations: {RESORT_LIST: [{name, drive_minutes, base_inches, new_24h, condition, chain_status}]} Return JSON only: { "picks": [{ "name": string, "drive_display": "2h 40m", "recommendation": "2 sentence reason — why this resort today given drive time and conditions", "key_stat": "e.g. 6 inches overnight, lifts 24/28", "urgency": "leave by 6am"|"leave by 7am"|"flexible" },], "overall_tip": "one sentence — best overall advice for this morning" }

Prompt C — Is it Worth the Drive?

Quick ski-day decision assistant. Resort: {RESORT_NAME} Drive: {DRIVE_TIME} from {USER_CITY} Base: {BASE}" | Overnight: {NEW_SNOW}" | 7-day: {NEW_7DAY}" | Condition: {CONDITION} Lifts: {LIFTS_OPEN}/{LIFTS_TOTAL} | Trails: {TRAILS_OPEN}/{TRAILS_TOTAL} Chain control: {CHAIN_STATUS} | Summit temp: {TEMP} F Answer in JSON: { "verdict": "strong yes"|"yes"|"borderline"|"probably not", "headline": "one punchy sentence — e.g. 'Prime powder day. Don't overthink it.'", "pros": ["up to 3 bullet points, very short"], "cons": ["up to 2 bullet points, very short"], "tip": "one practical tip for this specific resort today" }

14. Financial Projections

Year 1 — Building the Business

	Month 1	Month 3	Month 6	Month 9	Month 12	Notes
Monthly Users	500	2,000	10,000	40,000	80,000	Organic + paid growth
Pro Subscribers	10	80	400	1,600	3,200	5% conversion rate
Subscription Rev	\$50	\$400	\$2,000	\$8,000	\$16,000	At \$4.99/mo avg
Ad Revenue	\$0	\$20	\$300	\$2,000	\$5,000	AdSense, ski CPMs
Total Revenue	\$50	\$420	\$2,300	\$10,000	\$21,000	MRR
Costs (API+Hosting)	\$80	\$150	\$400	\$1,200	\$2,000	Anthropic + Vercel + Supabase
Net	-\$30	\$270	\$1,900	\$8,800	\$19,000	Growing margin

Revenue Streams Ranked by Priority

- **Priority 1:** Pro subscriptions — highest margin, most scalable, predictable recurring revenue. Build this first.
- **Priority 2:** Google AdSense — passive income from free users. Add from day one, ignore the small numbers early.
- **Priority 3:** Affiliate / hotel links — partner with Booking.com or Expedia, earn 4–6% on lodging bookings near resorts. Add at Month 3.
- **Priority 4:** Annual plan upsell — \$29.99/year vs \$4.99/month saves the user money and locks in 12 months of revenue for you. Promote aggressively.
- **Priority 5:** Family plan — \$7.99/month for 4 users. Increases LTV per household. Implement at Month 6.

The bottom line: Powder is a real business in a proven market with clear competitors who have validated the pricing model. The prototype is strong. The gap is real. The path from prototype to \$10K MRR is 12–18 months of consistent execution. Start by deploying today, get your first 10 paying users this month, and iterate from there.